HANDS-ON n8n PRACTICE

Build Your First Workflow

Four workflows, one step at a time: from a single AI call to a multi-branch alert system.



The practice ladder

Each workflow adds one new idea. Finish one before climbing to the next.

1

Hello AI

New: Nodes, items, credentials

2

Daily Weather Alert

New: Schedules, If logic, Gmail

3

AI News Digest

New: RSS trigger, LLM chain, expressions

4

Solar Flare Alert

New: Branching, structured output, HTTP

Before you start

Get these ready once. Every workflow in this session reuses them.

✓	**n8n account**	n8n Cloud trial, or run it locally with `npx n8n`
✓	**OpenAI API key**	platform.openai.com → API keys (add a little billing credit)
✓	**OpenWeatherMap key**	Free signup at openweathermap.org → API keys
✓	**Gmail**	Sign in with Google inside the Gmail node (one click on n8n Cloud)
✓	**NASA API key**	Free and instant at api.nasa.gov

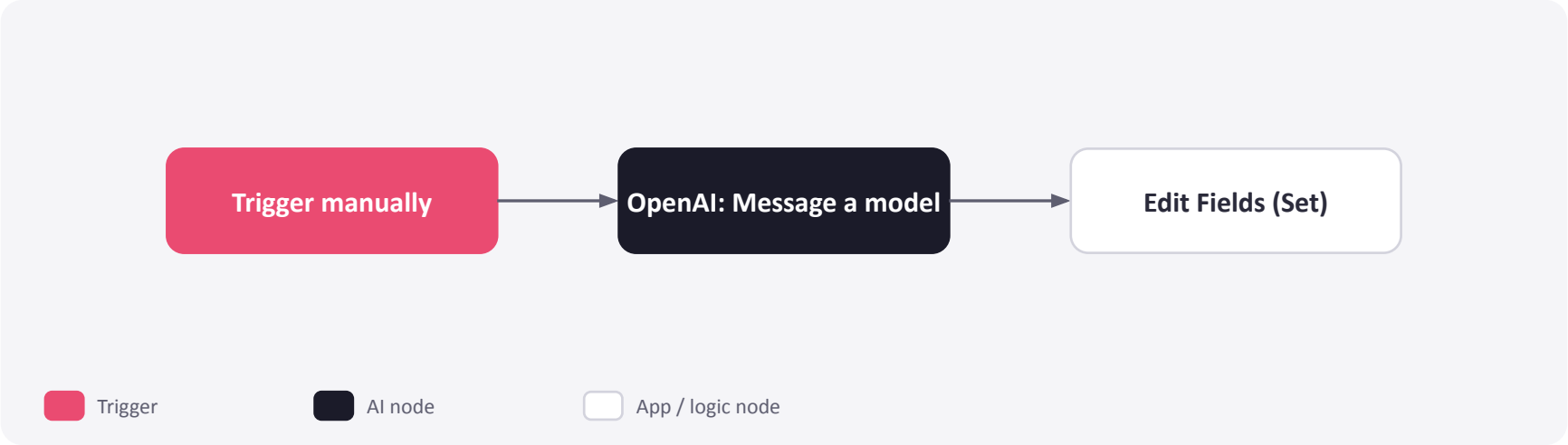
Golden rule

Number every workflow (01, 02…) and download it as JSON when it works. Your work never gets lost.

WORKFLOW 01

Hello AI

Level 1 · Warm-up



Goal

Send one prompt to an AI model and read the answer inside n8n.

You'll learn

Triggers, nodes, how data flows as items, and connecting a credential.

Build it: Hello AI

About 10 minutes

1

Create the workflow

Click Create workflow and name it `01 – Hello AI`.

2

Add the trigger

Pick Trigger manually. The flow runs only when you click Execute.

3

Add the AI node

Click +, search OpenAI, choose Message a model. Select your credential and `gpt-4o-mini`.

4

Write the prompt

Type: Explain what n8n is to a finance manager in 3 short lines.

5

Clean the output

Add Edit Fields (Set). Create a field `answer` and drag the reply text into it from the left panel.

6

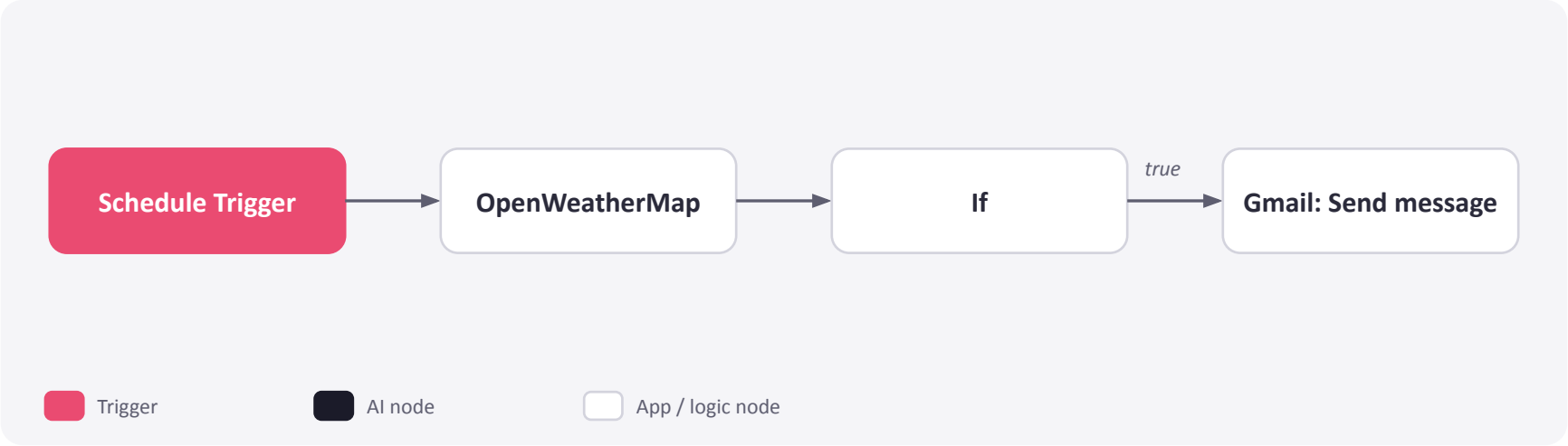
Run and inspect

Click Execute workflow. Open each node to see its input and output, then Save.

WORKFLOW 02

Daily Weather Alert

Level 2 · Basic



Goal

Every morning, check the weather and send an email only when it is a hot day.

You'll learn

Schedule triggers, app nodes, If conditions, and sending email.

Build it: Daily Weather Alert

Create the OpenWeatherMap key before class: new keys can take a couple of hours to activate.

1

Schedule it

New workflow `02 - Weather Alert`. Add Schedule Trigger: every day at 7:00 AM.

2

Get the weather

Add OpenWeatherMap → Current Weather. City: `Bengaluru`, Format: Metric. Add your API key.

3

Find the temperature

Execute the node. In the output, the temperature sits at `main.temp`.

4

Add the condition

Add If. Drag `main.temp` into value 1, choose Number → is greater than, value 2: `30`.

5

Send the email

On the true output add Gmail → Send a message. Message: It is `{{ $json.main.temp }}` °C today. Carry water!

6

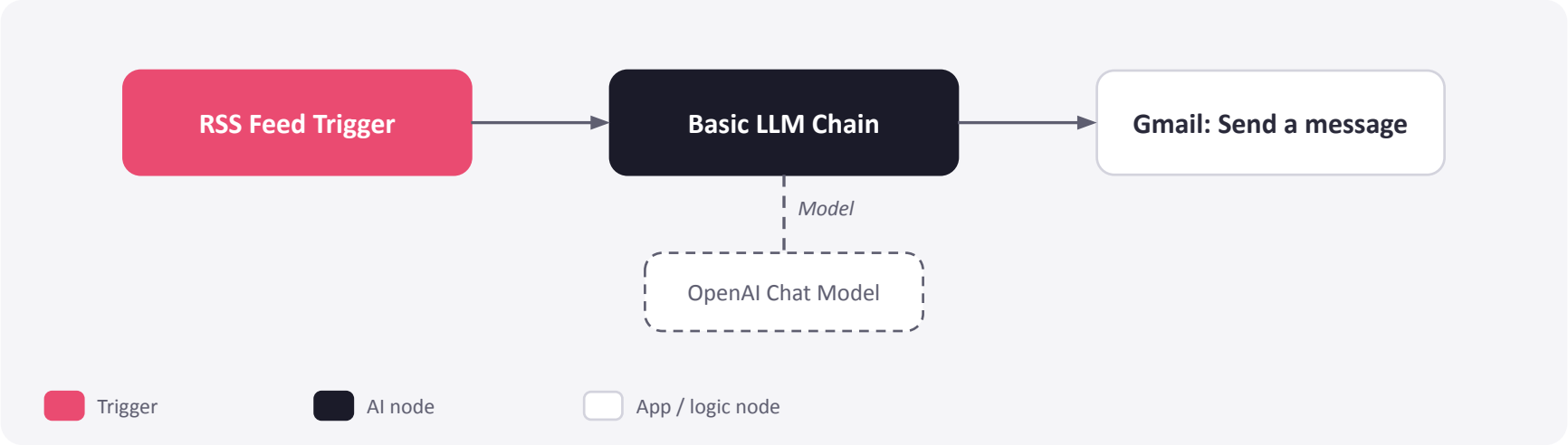
Test, then activate

Set the limit to 10 so it passes, run, check your inbox. Reset to 30 and activate.

WORKFLOW 03

AI News Digest

Level 3 · Basic + AI



Goal

When a new article appears in a news feed, AI summarises it and emails you.

You'll learn

RSS triggers, the Basic LLM Chain, plugging in a model, and expressions.

Build it: AI News Digest

The chain holds the prompt; the model plugs in underneath, so you can swap models without rebuilding.

1 Add the RSS trigger

New workflow `03 – AI News Digest`. RSS Feed Trigger, poll every hour. Feed: `https://feeds.bbci.co.uk/news/technology/rss.xml`

2 Load a test article

Click Fetch test event. Note the fields: `title`, `link`, `contentSnippet`.

3 Add Basic LLM Chain

Prompt: Define below. Summarise in 3 points for a busy manager: `{{ $json.title }} {{ $json.contentSnippet }}`

4 Plug in the model

Click Model + under the chain → OpenAI Chat Model → your credential → `gpt-4o-mini`.

5 Email the summary

Gmail → Send a message. Subject: `{{ $('RSS Feed Trigger').item.json.title }}` Message: `{{ $json.text }}`

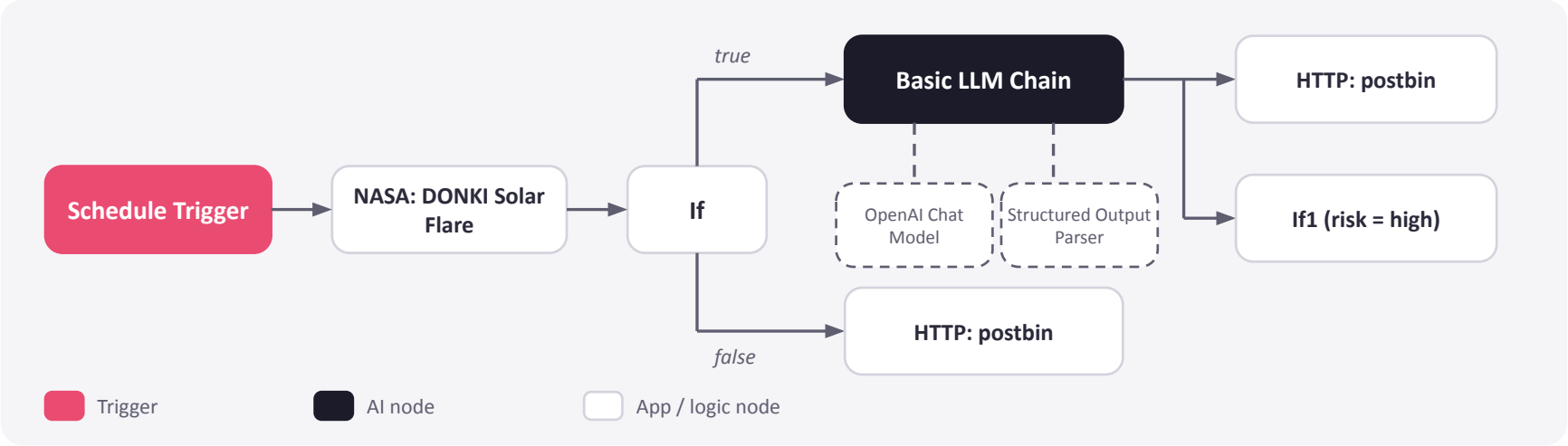
6 Test, then activate

Execute the workflow and read the email. Once active, new articles arrive on their own.

WORKFLOW 04

Solar Flare Alert

Level 4 · Advanced



Goal

Daily check of NASA data. Strong flares get an AI explanation and an alert; minor ones are logged.

You'll learn

Two-way branching, structured AI output (JSON), and the HTTP Request node.

Build it: Solar Flare Alert (part 1)

Fetch the data and split strong flares from minor ones.

1 Schedule it

New workflow `04 - Solar Flare Alert`. Schedule Trigger: every day at 9:00 AM.

2 Call NASA

Add NASA → DONKI Solar Flare → Get. Key from api.nasa.gov. Keep default dates (last 30 days) for test data.

3 Read the data

Execute. Each flare is one item. Check `classType` (C, M or X), `peakTime`, `sourceLocation`.

4 Filter strong flares

If: `classType` starts with `X`, OR starts with `M`. True = strong flare, false = minor.

5 Log minor flares

On false add HTTP Request (Send a request1): POST to your webhook.site URL with the class in a JSON body.

Tip webhook.site gives you a free test URL and shows every request n8n sends to it. Perfect for class.

Build it: Solar Flare Alert (part 2)

Let AI explain strong flares in fixed fields, then send the alert.

6 Add the AI chain

On true add Basic LLM Chain. Turn on Require Specific Output Format. Use the prompt from the next slide.

7 Model + parser

Model → OpenAI Chat Model. Output Parser → Structured Output Parser with the JSON example.

8 Post the alert

HTTP Request (Send a request): POST to webhook.site with `{{ $json.output.headline }}` and friends.

9 Check the risk

Also connect the chain to If1: `{{ $json.output.risk_level }}` is equal to `high`.

10 Run end to end

Execute, watch both branches arrive on webhook.site, then activate.

Tip Stretch goal: connect the true output of If1 to Gmail for an urgent email.

Copy-paste snippets: Solar Flare Alert

The parser forces the AI to reply in fixed fields, so the next nodes can use them reliably.

Basic LLM Chain: prompt

```
You explain space weather to non-scientists. A class {{ $json.classType }} solar flare
peaked at {{ $json.peakTime }} from {{ $json.sourceLocation }}. Explain what happened in
simple words and rate the risk to satellites, GPS and radio.
```

Structured Output Parser: JSON example

```
{
  "headline": "Strong solar flare today",
  "summary": "2-3 simple sentences",
  "risk_level": "low"
}
```

Send a request: JSON body

```
{
  "headline": "{{ $json.output.headline }}",
  "summary": "{{ $json.output.summary }}",
  "risk": "{{ $json.output.risk_level }}"
}
```

Your turn

One small change per workflow. Break it, fix it, and it sticks.

01 Rewrite the prompt so it explains n8n for your own job role.

02 Alert on rain instead of heat: check `weather[0].main` equals Rain.

03 Swap in a news feed from your own industry.

04 Wire If1 to Gmail so high-risk flares reach your inbox.

Done? Save, then download each workflow as JSON.